

PRAXIS AND MINISTRY

We Speak Because We Have First Been Spoken: A Grammar of the Preaching Life, Michael Pasquarello III, Eerdmans Publishing, 2009 (ISBN 978-0-8028-2917-7), viii + 158 pp., pb \$18.00

Professor of Preaching at Asbury Theological Seminary in Kentucky, Michael Pasquarello III, authors a book on preaching that focuses on the life of the preacher rather than the content of her sermon. Yet, the content is supremely in view. Dependent upon a theological Wittgensteinianism, Pasquarello argues that the preacher's life is the content of her words, that the preacher must be holy if her sermons are to be true. In this sense, preachers speak because they have first been spoken.

The first chapter sees Pasquarello relying primarily upon Rowan Williams's essay 'Theological Integrity' (*New Blackfriars* 1991: 140–51) in order to make the claim that theological speech requires a certain holiness, not trite middle-class prudishness but the penitent purgation of idolatrous values, motivations, and goals which taint even the noblest of deeds and the purest devotion. Pasquarello mixes this rather freely with Hauerwas's emphasis on church practices and Bonhoeffer's critique of religion, but does not move beyond the more general claim that Christian truth is inseparable from a sacrificial, self-emptying form of life.

The next four chapters consist of variations on this theme, with Thomas Aquinas being a central conversation partner. The main thrust can be described as an attempt to revision the life of the preacher in terms of the Trinitarian life of God, an impassioned plea for preachers to pause looking outside the church for the meaning of their message and to return to the Word through the daily habits of contemplation, prayer, service, and worship.

Pasquarello can be praised for writing a book on preaching that places more emphasis on the vocation than on homiletical technique. It is also encouraging that he takes theology and holiness so seriously. He calls for preachers to be theologians and saints, not merely rhetoricians or Bible lecturers. And his breadth of reading is evident on every page.

In fact, if there is a fault with this book, it is that Pasquarello's preference for lengthy quotation is cumbersome. The author is so successful at

showcasing his sources that he unfortunately seems to bury his point with them, or, at least, the barrage of secondary interaction overwhelms readers to the point of distracting them from the claims being made. It is rather surprising that a preacher, more, a professor of preachers, has so little of his own to say. With regret I am afraid to conclude that this book is a bit too raw, too constipated by undigested quotation to be nourishing.

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The Promise of Despair: The Way of the Cross as The Way of the Church, Andrew Root, Abingdon Press, 2010 (ISBN 978-1-426-70062-0), xxix + 161 pp., pb \$19.95

For best-selling authors like Bruce Wilkerson and Joel Osteen, faith in Jesus Christ enables Christians to live happy, healthy, and materially abundant lives. 'Purpose-Driven' churches subdivide congregations into small groups around common interests. The paradigm of the 'seeker-friendly Church', suburban Chicago's Willow Creek Church, removed its sanctuary cross after surveys showed it made worshipers uncomfortable. Into this plethora of books filled with beautiful, smiling people meeting with extraordinary success comes Andrew Root's deeply personal, relentlessly honest, and theologically well-grounded treatment of life as most Christians live it: full of grace amid death, illness, and sorrow. Despite our unwillingness to name these realities, Root knows that faith cannot prevent tragedy, despair, and death. Refusing to let death hide in academic language, Root poignantly describes the death of a childhood friend and the ways that it shaped him.

This book about suffering is grounded by Luther's theology of the Cross in a powerful, persuasive, and pastoral way. Root is faithful to Luther's texts, but applies them in meaningful and contemporary ways. Like most 'Emergent Church' thinkers, Root illuminates the present by drawing from contemporary philosophical and cultural analysis. While avoiding both obtuse jargon and over simplification, Root uses Jean Baudrillard's concept of the 'spectacle' to helpfully and practically attend to the constant barrage of images (what Baudrillard calls the 'hyper-real') that promise happiness. In contrast to media illusions, Root finds that the church's witness can be a visible purveyor of truth telling amid painful reality. He does not promise that faith will give one happiness, prosperity, or self-esteem, but, drawing heavily on Luther's